Word Bank

Accepted words and phrases for advanced learners of English

14 entries · updated 12 October 2026

British pronunciations come, where available, from Wiktionary (en.wiktionary.org), under the Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike licence, via kaikki.org. Quotations are from The Guardian.

Contents

Words 3

anaphora . . . 3
contingent . . . 3
husbandry . . . 4
inconsequential . . . 5
philanderer . . . 5
portend . . . 6
simper . . . 6
tergiversate . . . 7
tortuous . . . 8
trumpery . . . 8

Phrases 10

Buridan's ass . . . 10
by and large . . . 10
ménage à trois . . . 11
prima donna . . . 12

Words

anaphora

uh-NAF-uh-ruh /əˈnæf.ə.rə/

A rhetorical device repeating a word or phrase at the start of successive clauses.

MEANINGS

1. **noun** A rhetorical device repeating a word or phrase at the start of successive clauses or sentences.
2. **noun** The use of a linguistic element that refers back to something previously mentioned.

EXAMPLES

Anaphora – repeating a word or phrase at the beginning of successive sentences or paragraphs – gives a speech force and momentum.

— The Guardian, 04 Feb 2019

Anaphora is the repetition of the same word at the beginning of successive sentences, clauses, lines or verses – it’s from the Greek, meaning “carrying back”.

— The Guardian, 21 Apr 2015

You notice he leans heavily on the repetition games of anaphora (repeating a word or phrase at the beginning of successive sentences), epistrophe (repeating one at the end) and symploce (doing both things at once, sandwich-style).

— The Guardian, 16 Jan 2017

The poet’s anaphora of ‘we’ in the speech gave it a stirring, collective rhythm.

— Example sentence

We shall fight on the beaches, we shall fight on the landing grounds, we shall fight in the fields.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

repetition, reiterative structure, parallelism, reiterated phrase, redundancy

ANTONYMS

variation, non-repetition

contingent

con-TIN-jent /kənˈtɪn.dʒənt/

Limited in number or dependent on certain conditions.

MEANINGS

1. **adjective** Dependent on something else; conditional or provisional.
2. **noun** A group of people representing an organisation or country, often at an event.

EXAMPLES

The Israel-Lebanon ceasefire is contingent on a complete cessation of fire from the Iran-aligned Hezbollah militia and the evacuation of all its operatives from the country’s south, a joint statement released by the US state department said after negotiations in Washington.

— The Guardian, 04 Jun 2026

The party argues that in some countries such as Germany and the Netherlands, unemployment payments are contingent on sufficient contributions having been made and can be time-limited.

— The Guardian, 23 Sep 2026

The base now being planned is just 100 metres by 120 metres and is intended to house a contingent of Moroccan troops, who would rotate from a base in Israel, the source said.

— The Guardian, 06 Aug 2026

The project's success is contingent on securing further funding.

— Example sentence

Her promotion is contingent upon passing the final assessment.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

dependent, conditional, group, delegation, party

ANTONYMS

independent, unconditional

husbandry

HUBZ-uhn-dree /ˈhʌzb(ə)ndri/

The art or practice of cultivating land and caring for livestock.

MEANINGS

1. **noun** The science or practice of farming, especially the breeding and care of livestock.
2. **noun** Careful management of resources or money, showing thriftiness.

EXAMPLES

Animal husbandry accounts for close to three-quarters of global use of antimicrobial medications and in many countries their use is poorly monitored.

— The Guardian, 03 Jun 2026

When a ram tips its head back, curls its upper lip, and takes a deep breath – what is known in the world of animal husbandry as a “flehmen response” – it is often a sign of arousal.

— The Guardian, 05 Dec 2025

Reindeer husbandry, Busch said at one press conference, “is an industry that affects very large areas, but has limited economic significance”.

— The Guardian, 07 Sep 2026

The farm's husbandry has improved the quality of its dairy products.

— Example sentence

She studied animal husbandry at the university to become a vet.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

farming, agriculture, cultivation, resource management, thrift

ANTONYMS

wastefulness, profligacy, neglect

inconsequential

in-kuhn-SEC-wen-shul /ˌɪnkən'sɛkwənʃəl/

Not important; having little or no effect.

MEANINGS

1. **adjective** Not important; of little significance or influence.
2. **adjective** Having no effect or impact; negligible.

EXAMPLES

The longest State of the Union speech in history was also one of the most inconsequential.

— The Guardian, 25 Feb 2026

“As with many jobs, there was also some contractor error done by rushing the job,” he wrote, claiming that the damage caused by those mistakes was limited to “a very small area” and was “relatively inconsequential”.

— The Guardian, 11 Sep 2026

Following the conclusion of this weekend’s round of Premier League fixtures, football fans have what promises to be an exceptionally long, uninspiring and largely inconsequential international break to endure.

— The Guardian, 17 Sep 2026

The typo in the footnote was inconsequential to the overall argument.

— Example sentence

She brushed off the comment as inconsequential and moved on with her presentation.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

trivial, insignificant, unimportant, minor, negligible

ANTONYMS

significant, important, consequential

philanderer

fi-LAN-duh-ruh /fɪ'lændərə/

A man who engages in many casual sexual relationships.

MEANINGS

1. **noun** Man who habitually has casual sexual relationships with women.
2. **noun** Man who deceives women by making false romantic promises.

EXAMPLES

This home-loving husband is also a pathological liar, serial philanderer, murderer, carpenter and, most famously, a traveller.

— The Guardian, 04 Jul 2026

She plays Lois, a painter in 1920s Paris, married to a handsome art dealer (Alan Bates), a philanderer who invites a beautiful penniless young woman (Isabelle Adjani) to stay with them – for the purposes of seducing her.

— The Guardian, 27 Sep 2024

Far from being the stereotypical reclusive genius, labouring in isolation, Crick was loud-talking and charismatic, a philanderer, poetry lover and thrower of risque parties.

— The Guardian, 25 Nov 2025

He was known in the town as a philanderer, leaving a trail of broken hearts.
— Example sentence

The scandalous newspaper exposed the politician as a serial philanderer.
— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

womaniser, rake, Casanova, Lothario

ANTONYMS

monogamist, faithful husband

portend

POR-tend /ˈpɔːˌtɛnd/

to be a sign or warning of something about to happen

MEANINGS

1. **verb** To be a sign or warning that something, especially something unpleasant, will happen.

EXAMPLES

The scale of Meta’s reshaping is staggering, though, and may portend what’s to come across all of tech; we have not seen a tech giant cut up to a fifth of its workforce to offset just how massive its AI spending has become.
— The Guardian, 24 Mar 2026

The fact that the last three of his top-10 victories had all come against Fritz didn’t exactly portend a star turn against Alcaraz – who entered Tuesday’s match with a 3-0 record against Shelton.
— The Guardian, 09 Sep 2026

Mass layoffs at the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) portend a future with more infectious disease outbreaks, chronic conditions, and a widening gulf in health between the most affluent and vulnerable, experts told the Guardian.
— The Guardian, 09 Apr 2025

The sudden rise in oil prices portended a looming recession.
— Example sentence

The darkening sky portended an approaching storm.
— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

foreshadow, herald, presage, augur, signal

ANTONYMS

refute, contradict

simper

SIM-puh /ˈsɪmpə/

To smile self-consciously and affectedly.

MEANINGS

1. **verb** To smile or speak in a self-conscious, affected manner, often showing nervous amusement.
2. **noun** A self-conscious, affected smile or giggle.

EXAMPLES

Welch was a strong, powerful personality, who didn’t simper or blush but looked permanently amused, as if she could eat any of her admirers for breakfast.
— The Guardian, 15 Feb 2023

Nevertheless, the screenplay still finds time to let her simper a bit at handsome British officer Ellis (Ben Lamb) whose fate is entwined with hers.
— The Guardian, 11 Dec 2020

These women simper over their church’s charismatic and politically ambitious preacher, who harangues them every Sunday, and also over the church’s platoon of young male volunteer street vigilantes who they are expected to marry.
— The Guardian, 10 Jul 2023

She tried not to simper when the interview panel praised her work.
— Example sentence

His simpering grin made the audience cringe rather than laugh.
— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

smirk, giggle coyly, grin affectedly, coy smile

ANTONYMS

frown, scowl

tergiversate

TER-ji-vuh-sayt /ˈtɜːdʒɪvəseɪt/

To change opinions frequently; to be indecisive or evasive.

MEANINGS

1. **verb** To change one's loyalties or opinions, especially deceitfully, often to suit personal advantage.
2. **verb** To use ambiguous or evasive language so as to avoid committing to a clear stance.

EXAMPLES

The politician tergiversated on the tax policy, promising cuts one week and raising them the next.
— Example sentence

She was accused of tergiversating during the interview, never giving a straight answer.
— Example sentence

His tergiversating about the project's timeline left the team uncertain.
— Example sentence

After the scandal, the CEO began to tergiversate, offering vague assurances rather than concrete plans.
— Example sentence

The committee's tergiversating over the new policy caused delays.
— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

equivocate, vacillate, waver, flip-flop, be evasive

ANTONYMS

be straightforward, be consistent, be candid

tortuous

TOR-choo-əs /ˈtɔːtʃuːəs/

full of twists and turns; complex

MEANINGS

1. **adjective** Having many twists, turns or bends; winding and not straight.
2. **adjective** Complex, difficult to follow because of intricate or devious structure.

EXAMPLES

In a tricky and tortuous opening to the Tour that will test every rider’s mettle, the biggest threat to Pogacar will be crashing.

— The Guardian, 04 Jul 2025

Frank Warren believes that the tortuous negotiations surrounding the proposed fight between Anthony Joshua and Tyson Fury are subject to a time limit which will run out by the end of next week.

— The Guardian, 26 Aug 2026

A jury was sworn in last week after a tortuous legal process and nearly nine years after her death.

— The Guardian, 09 Jul 2026

The tortuous mountain road forced the drivers to navigate each hairpin bend carefully.

— Example sentence

She described the tortuous legal argument as bewildering even for seasoned solicitors.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

winding, circuitous, sinuous, twisty

ANTONYMS

straight, direct, simple

trumpery

TRUM-puh-ree /ˈtrʌmpəri/

showy, superficial, and worthless ornamentation

MEANINGS

1. **noun** Showy, superficial ornamentation that lacks real value or substance.

EXAMPLES

More hopeful moments like that, and a good deal less trumpery, are badly needed now.

— The Guardian, 27 Apr 2024

Trumpery (OED): practices or beliefs that are superficially or visually appealing but have little real value or worth.

— The Guardian, 23 May 2017

According to the Merriam-Webster dictionary, the word “trumpery” first appeared in English in the mid-15th century with the meaning “worthless nonsense.”.

— The Guardian, 06 Oct 2025

The ballroom was filled with trumpery, glittering chandeliers and gilded mirrors that added little beyond visual fluff.

— Example sentence

His speech was a parade of trumpery, full of grandiose phrases but no concrete proposals.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

frippery, tinsel, baubles, flashiness, foppery

ANTONYMS

substance, authenticity

Phrases

Buridan's ass

BUH-ri-dənz ASS /ˈbʊrɪdənz ˈæs/

a paradox of indecision when faced with equal choices

MEANINGS

1. **idiom** A situation where a person cannot choose between two equally attractive options and thus takes no action.
2. **phrase** The philosophical paradox of a donkey that starves when presented with two identical piles of hay.

EXAMPLES

Small comfort, perhaps, that we are not like Buridan's ass, starving between identical piles of hay.

— The Guardian, 31 Aug 2002

This is not the fault of management at RBS and Lloyds, they appear to have been given conflicting goals and like Buridan's ass are mid way between a stack of hay and a pail of water.

— The Guardian, 16 Jul 2010

38 min: Neither of these teams want to die like Buridan's ass so there's both now hellbent on victory, meaning the game is becoming ever more open and entertaining.

— The Guardian, 23 Jun 2010

Faced with a promotion and a sabbatical, he was a real Buridan's ass, unable to decide.

— Example sentence

The committee became Buridan's ass, stuck between two equally persuasive proposals.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

indecision, stalemate, deadlock, paralysis of choice

ANTONYMS

decisiveness, resolution

by and large

generally; on the whole

MEANINGS

1. **idiom** Generally; on the whole, ignoring minor details.

EXAMPLES

By and large, the new timetable suits commuters better.

— Example sentence

The film was, by and large, enjoyable despite its predictable plot.

— Example sentence

By and large, British summers are quite mild, though occasional heatwaves occur.

— Example sentence

The committee, by and large, agreed to the proposed changes.

— Example sentence

By and large, the restaurant's service is prompt, though the kitchen can be slow at rush hour.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

overall, generally, in general, on the whole

ANTONYMS

specifically, in detail, precisely

ménage à trois

a three-person romantic relationship

MEANINGS

1. **idiom** A romantic or sexual relationship involving three people, typically a couple and a third partner.
2. **idiom** A three-person partnership in non-romantic contexts, such as business or creative collaborations.

EXAMPLES

Delon’s relationships with women were notorious, including persuading two actresses – Mireille Darc and Maddly Bamy – to engage in a ménage à trois in the late 1960s, declaring he was unable to decide which he loved best.

— The Guardian, 20 Jan 2024

Rachel (Kate Dickie) and Dominic (Adrian Rawlins) find themselves in an awkward ménage à trois when her ex-husband, whom she prefers, returns from the post-apocalyptic realm after 15 years.

— The Guardian, 11 May 2021

He is rescued and seduced into a ménage à trois by an expat couple whose professed colour blindness inevitably comes in for ribbing: “Black, white!

— The Guardian, 16 Jul 2020

After months of dating, they announced their ménage à trois was working surprisingly well.

— Example sentence

The novel explores a ménage à trois between the protagonist, his wife, and her sister.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

three-way relationship, throuple, triad, polyamorous trio

ANTONYMS

monogamy, pair relationship

prima donna

pree-MA DON-uh /ˌpriːməˈdɒnə/

A demanding, temperamental person, especially a self-important performer.

MEANINGS

1. **noun phrase** The lead female singer in an opera or a distinguished female vocalist.
2. **idiom** A person, often a woman, who behaves in an overly self-important, demanding, or temperamental way.

EXAMPLES

The prima donna started as a chorus pig on Henson’s The Muppet Show before gradually becoming a bigger part of the series, and stealing the spotlight from her froggy beau Kermit.

— The Guardian, 05 Nov 2025

11 February 2003 The “petulant prima donna of realpolitik” is leading the “axis of weasels”, in “a chorus of cowards”.

— The Guardian, 18 Mar 2026

Renamed Felix, treated for chronic catarrh and mutually ignored by Barsie, our resident feline, Felix led the happy lethargic life of a superannuated prima donna, stirring only to plonk himself down wherever poor Barsie chose to sit.

— The Guardian, 15 Feb 2024

The soprano was a true prima donna, commanding the stage with effortless grace.

— Example sentence

After the rehearsal, she threw a tantrum; everyone knew she was a prima donna.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

diva, self-important person, high-maintenance performer, temperamental star

ANTONYMS

team player, humble performer